> journey, Levitan [the announcer] broadcasts the letter – and the world is saved![21]

The possibility that the fate of the earth depended on the workings of a decrepit lift, however, seems unlikely. Lebow and Stein explain that protocol required formal delivery of Khrushchev's letter to the US embassy.[22] This also encountered problems when KGB-organised demonstrations blocked delivery of the message, which arrived at the embassy shortly after it was broadcast on Radio Moscow.

While Secretary General Thant worked to mediate, he provided a sketch of what a golden bridge might look light. In his remarks to the Security Council on 24 October, he suggested an arrangement in which construction of the missile bases would come to a verified standstill in return for American assurances they would not invade Cuba in the next few weeks.[23] In the ensuing days, he privately pressed this idea of a non-invasion pledge.

The problem of the missiles in Cuba, however, remained unresolved as the blockade proceeded. General Pliyev followed orders from Moscow to accelerate preparation of the bases. By Friday, 26 October the MRBM sites were 'operational,' although US intelligence had still not detected any nuclear warheads in Cuba (none of which had in any case arrived at the missile sites). Meanwhile, American preparations for an attack and invasion gathered apace.

The restaurant at the end of the world

On Friday, 26 October the first signs of a diplomatic breakthrough began to appear in Washington. Secretary General Thant sent messages to the State Department, and phoned Dean Rusk to say he thought the Soviets might be amenable to withdrawing their missiles in return for a US pledge not to invade Cuba.[24] Second, a similar proposal appeared to come from a senior intelligence officer at the Soviet embassy. Third, President Kennedy received a letter from Premier Khrushchev suggesting Moscow was seriously interested in resolving the crisis through diplomacy. As Roger Hilsman put it, Friday, 26 October was the 'day … of the first real blink'.[25]